ANTWERP, BELGIUM

Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp: Masterpieces

Twenty works at the KMSKA in which clothing, objects and company help define a person's place.



Two portraits in this selection include working objects. Abraham Grapheus is surrounded by elaborate vessels and guild ornaments; the Antwerp street sweeper has the long handle of a tool. Both pictures identify people through a public role, yet neither is exhausted by that role.

Across these twenty works, the relation between a person and their surroundings keeps changing. An oyster meal competes with its diner for attention. A wedding becomes a procession of many participants. In two paintings of Calvary, the same subject is organised through different distances between bodies. These comparisons offer a way into the Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp without turning the selection into a ranking of its most famous pictures.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/royal-fine-arts-antwerp

The selection · 20

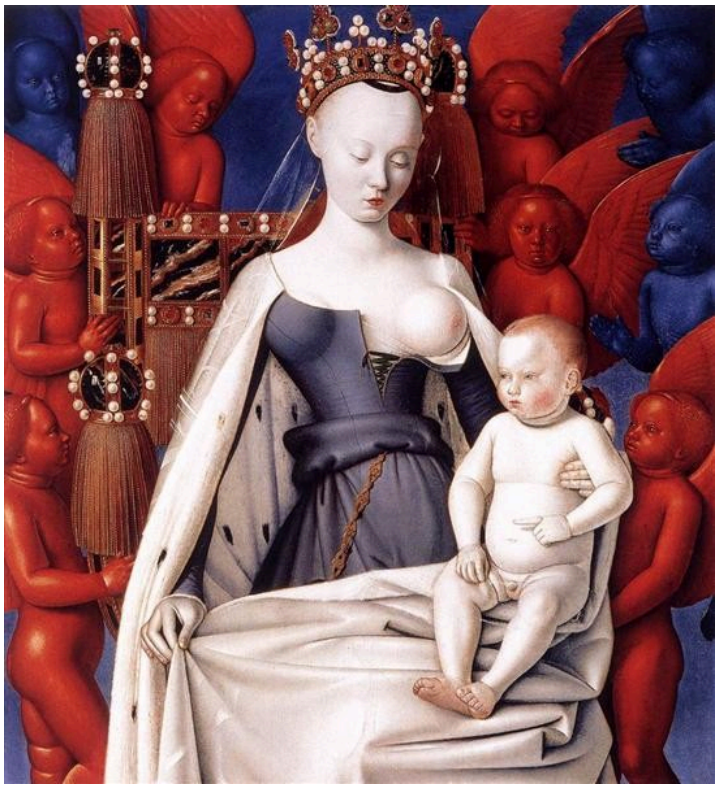
1. Madonna Surrounded by Seraphim and Cherubim
   Jean Fouquet · c. 1450
2. The Oyster Eater
   James Ensor · 1882
3. Jacopo Pesaro Presented to Saint Peter by Pope Alexander VI
   Titian · 1503
4. Village Scene
   Peeter Bout · 1680
5. A Contrast
   Josef Lies · c. 1862
6. Abraham Grapheus
   Cornelis de Vos · 1620
7. Adam and Eve
   Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1528-1530
8. After Mourning
   Louis Thevenet · 1908
9. Albrecht Dürer Descends the Rhine
   Josef Lies · 1855
10. Aline
    Jan de Smedt · 1938
11. Old Woman
    Evert Larock · 1892
12. Antwerp Street Sweeper
    Pieter Van Havermaet · 1890
13. Antwerp Wedding
    Willem Linnig Junior · c. 1866
14. Arrival of the Procession
    Frans van Leemputten · c. 1903–1905
15. The Temptation of Saint Anthony
    James Ensor · 1927
16. Man at the Window
    Henri De Braekeleer · 1873
17. Calvary
    Antonello da Messina · 1475
18. Calvary
    Maerten de Vos · 1600
19. Studio of the Painter
    Henri De Braekeleer · 1873
20. Camilla in Blue
    Jan de Smedt · 1941

01 / 20

Madonna Surrounded by Seraphim and Cherubim

Jean Fouquet

c. 1450 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Jean Fouquet. Madonna and Child. Left Panel of Diptych de Melun. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The white Madonna and child stand apart from the intensely red and blue angels. Yet the child's gesture points beyond this self-contained arrangement: the painting was one half of a diptych, paired with the patron's prayer in the other panel. Its missing companion helps explain a connection that the Antwerp image cannot show on its own.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Oyster Eater

James Ensor

1882 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



James Ensor. The Oyster Eater. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The meal spreads across the picture in glasses, flowers, dishes and reflected colour. The woman remains present, but no clean boundary separates her from the table's abundance. It is useful to let attention move among the objects before returning to her: the portrait-like subject and the still life occupy the same occasion.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Jacopo Pesaro Presented to Saint Peter by Pope Alexander VI

Titian

1503 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Pope Alexander IV Presenting Jacopo Pesaro to St Peter. WikiArt; Titian. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Kneeling below Saint Peter, Pesaro enters a visible hierarchy whose positions do much of the explanatory work. The pope stands behind him; a military standard rises nearby. Religious approval and worldly authority meet in one arrangement, while the distant sea widens the setting beyond the immediate act of presentation.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Village Scene

Peeter Bout

1680 · Oil on panel · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Pieter Bout; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · CC0

No single exchange accounts for the whole village scene. Horses and people gather in separate clusters, and the opening between the buildings carries attention farther away. The smallness of the figures allows several activities to coexist. Reading the street means moving among them, rather than finding one principal character and treating the rest as background.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 27

05 / 20

A Contrast

Josef Lies

c. 1862 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Josef Lies. A contrast. Image credit: Josef Lies; Source credit: http://62.221.199.163/kmska2/zoom.aspx?image=1189.001.jpg&title=Een%20contrast. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The title asks for comparison, and the composition supplies it through clothing, position and tools. A finely dressed woman shares the scene with working figures whose circumstances are visibly different. The terrace brings those positions into proximity without making them equivalent. Social distinction becomes the picture's subject rather than incidental information about its people.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1189

06 / 20

Abraham Grapheus

Cornelis de Vos

1620 · Oil on panel · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Cornelis de Vos; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · CC0

Grapheus's apparent finery needs a second reading. The metal plates on his chest belong to the Antwerp guild's chamber of rhetoric, and the splendid vessels are guild property, not a straightforward display of personal wealth. The portrait joins an individual face to the institution he served; the objects identify a role as well as catching the light.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 104

07 / 20

Adam and Eve

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1528-1530 · Oil on panel · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Lucas Cranach I; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · CC0

The dark ground keeps the two pale bodies clearly separated, while small gestures connect them beneath the fruit tree. The offered fruit concentrates the narrative into a modest action. The painting does not require a crowded setting: a few bodily turns and the relationship between the figures establish the moment on which the larger story depends.

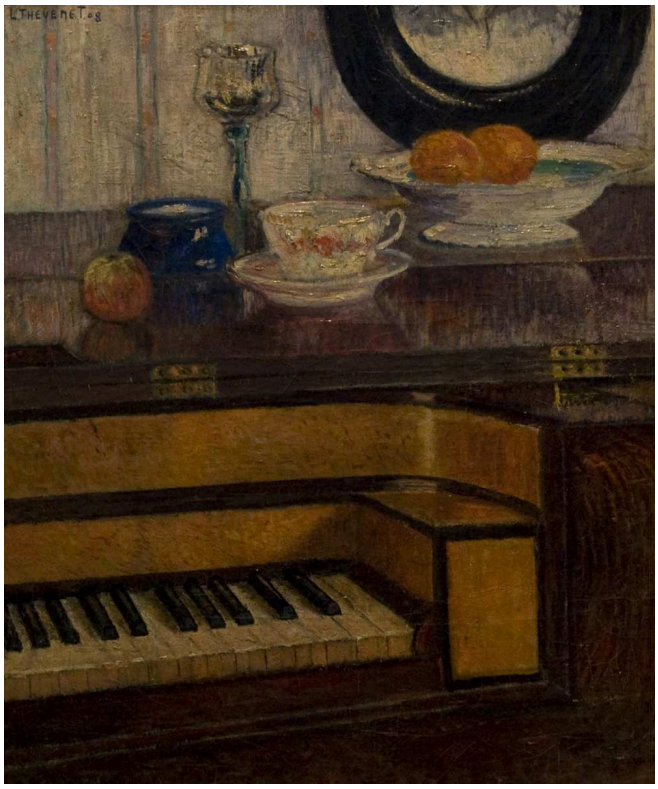
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 42

08 / 20

After Mourning

Louis Thevenet

1908 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Louis Thevenet. After the Mourning. Image credit: Louis Thevenet; Source credit: Own work (photo by Paul Hermans on 2010-02-28). Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Food, dishes and the keyboard remain in a room without visible inhabitants. The title introduces mourning, but the objects do not identify who has died or who has left. They give the scene a more limited, tangible subject: familiar things continuing to occupy their places when the people around whom a room is organised are absent.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2793

09 / 20

Albrecht Dürer Descends the Rhine

Josef Lies

1855 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Josef Lies. Albrecht Durer descends the Rhine. Image credit: Josef Lies; Source credit: http://62.221.199.163/kmska2/zoom.aspx?image=1100.001.jpg&title=Albrecht%20Dürer%20vaart%20de%20Rijn%20af. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The river journey belongs to Lies's nineteenth-century imagining of Dürer, not to an eyewitness record of his life. Costumes and the standing artist organise the boat into a historical scene. The painting is therefore evidence of how a later period pictured an earlier artist, a distinction worth keeping alongside its apparent narrative immediacy.

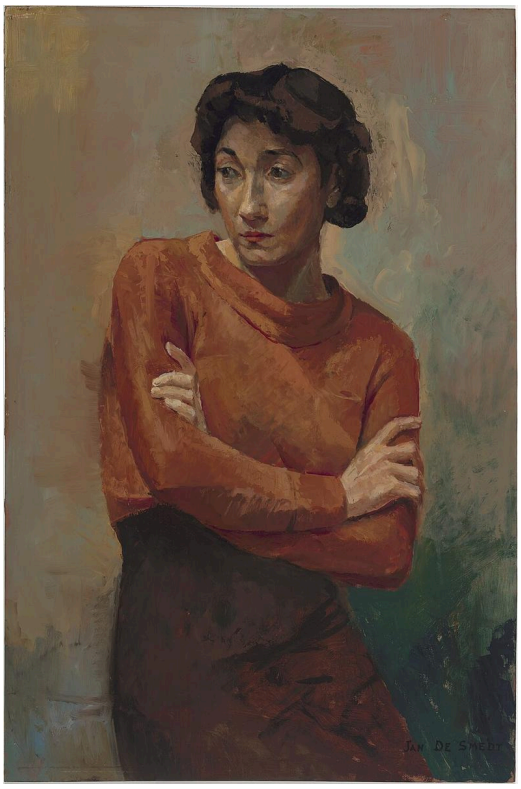
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1100

10 / 20

Aline

Jan de Smedt

1938 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Jan de Smedt. Aline. Image credit: Jan de Smedt; meemoo, Vlaams instituut voor het archief. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Aline_-_Jan_De_Smedt_-_KMSKA.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The folded arms establish a firm horizontal shape beneath the turn of the head. The orange blouse keeps that bodily arrangement prominent against the subdued ground. There is no setting to explain the sitter's mood, and her sideways gaze need not be translated into a fixed emotion. Posture is already a substantial part of the likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3533

11 / 20

Old Woman

Evert Larock

1892 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Evert Larock. An Old Woman. Image credit: Evert Larock; Source credit: Lukas - Art in Flanders. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The profile limits the information available about the face while making its contour unusually consequential. Warm browns bring the covered head close to the surrounding ground, so small shifts of tone must keep it distinct. The portrait gives age a visible presence without needing a symbolic object or a story about the sitter's life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2081

12 / 20

Antwerp Street Sweeper

Pieter Van Havermaet

1890 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Pieter Van Havermaet. Antwerp Street Sweeper. Image credit: Pieter Van Havermaet; Source credit: http://anet.be/record/opackmska/a::art.2523. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The long handle identifies an occupation, but the man is not reduced to a demonstration of sweeping. His face and resting hand give the portrait a pause within work. Compare him with Grapheus: both are accompanied by objects associated with a role, though the objects carry very different kinds of public status.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1292

13 / 20

Antwerp Wedding

Willem Linnig Junior

c. 1866 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Willem Linnig Junior. Antwerp wedding. Image credit: Willem Linnig Junior; Source credit: http://62.221.199.163/kmska2/zoom.aspx?image=1344.001.jpg&title=Antwerpse%20bruiloft. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The broad format gives the wedding room to unfold as a procession. Participants and onlookers contribute different positions within the ceremony, making the occasion larger than a portrait of the couple alone. Historical dress establishes the scene's register; the gathering should not be treated as a photograph-like record of an otherwise undocumented event.

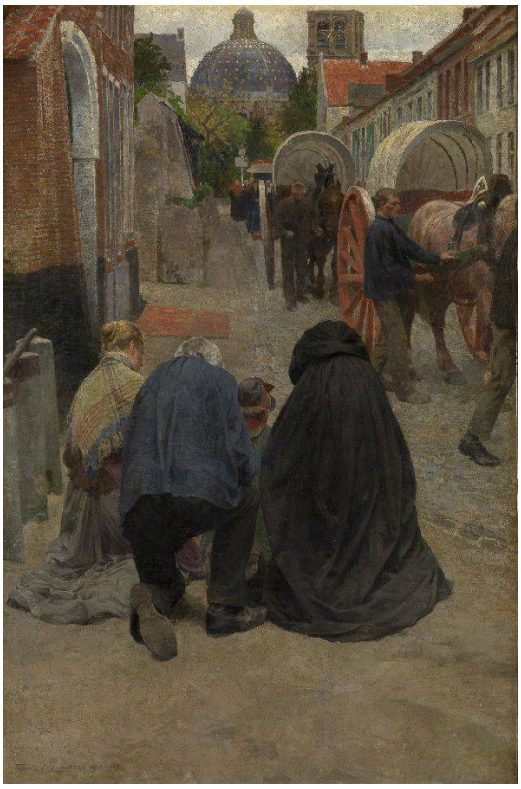
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1344

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Arrival of the Procession

Frans van Leemputten

c. 1903–1905 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Arrival of the Procession. Frans Van Leemputten; photograph: Hugo Maertens; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp – Flemish Community. Museum manifest: CC0 / public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

The bent figure in the foreground brings a public procession down to the scale of an individual movement. Beyond it, the carriage and participants occupy the street in greater numbers. The cobbles link these distances, allowing the event to approach without letting its collective spectacle erase the bodily action closest to the viewer.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1599b

15 / 20

The Temptation of Saint Anthony

James Ensor

1927 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



James Ensor. The Temptation of Saint Anthony the Great. Image credit: James Ensor; Source credit: This file was derived from: James Ensor - De verzoeking van de heilige Antonius - 4003 - Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp.tiff. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The threatening forms do not all acquire solid boundaries. Faces and bodies emerge through light marks and remain separated by areas of bare paper. For a scene of temptation, that unfinished-looking instability is useful: attention shifts between recognising a creature and losing it again among the surrounding suggestions.

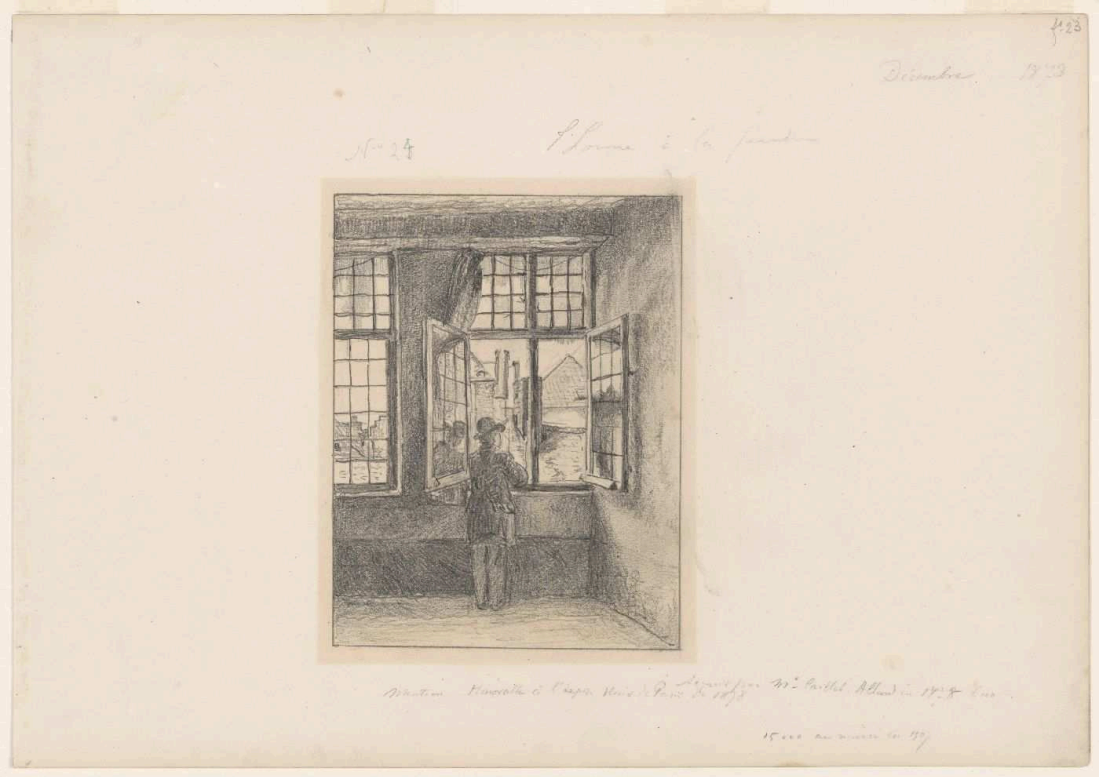
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4003

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Man at the Window

Henri De Braekeleer

1873 · Pencil on paper · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Henri De Braekeleer; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · CC0

The window provides the room with its largest contrast and the man with a place to stand. Dense pencil marks describe the enclosed interior around that lighter opening. The drawing offers little incident, but it establishes two directions of attention—toward the room and toward what lies beyond it—without having to depict a dramatic choice.

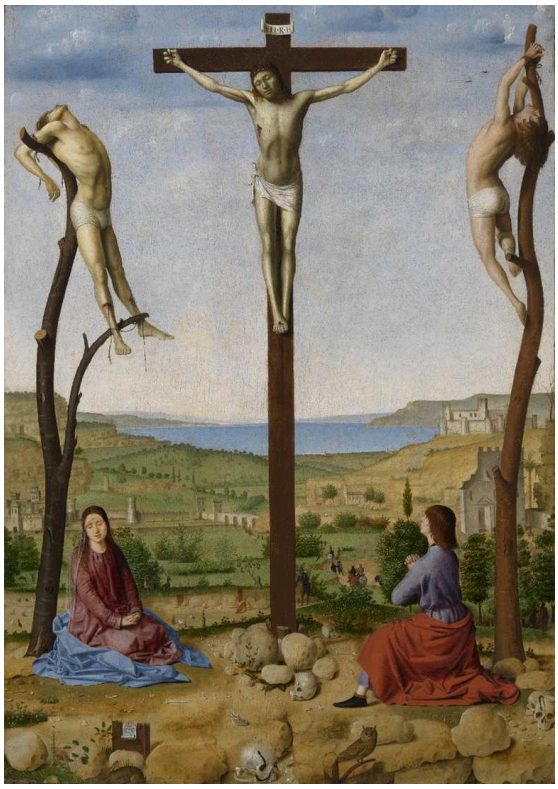
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1683/21

17 / 20

Calvary

Antonello da Messina

1475 · Oil on panel · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Antonello da Messina; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · CC0

Christ's straight cross differs from the rough trunks supporting the thieves. Those supports separate the bodies even before their poses are considered. The landscape continues behind the execution with a distance that the foreground figures cannot escape. Its calm recession makes the violence particularly exposed, rather than enclosing the whole scene in agitation.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4

18 / 20

Calvary

Maerten de Vos

1600 · Oil on canvas · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Maerten de Vos; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · CC0

The mourners gather close to the cross, one figure reaching around its base. Their gestures attempt a contact that the height of Christ's body makes incomplete. Compared with Antonello's more widely extended landscape, the weight of this scene falls on the group immediately below the crucified figure and the distance separating them from him.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 71

19 / 20

Studio of the Painter

Henri De Braekeleer

1873 · Graphite pencil on paper · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Henri De Braekeleer; Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · CC0

Pictures, easels and furniture occupy the studio alongside the standing painter. The different densities of graphite keep this accumulation readable without giving every object equal emphasis. It is a workplace organised around making and looking at images; the drawing itself adds another image to that activity rather than observing it from an entirely separate position.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1683/20

20 / 20

Camilla in Blue

Jan de Smedt

1941 · Royal Museum of Fine Arts Antwerp



Jan de Smedt. Camilla in parmezaans blauw. Image credit: Jan de Smedt; meemoo, Vlaams instituut voor het archief. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Camilla_in_parmezaans_blauw_-_Jan_De_Smedt_-_KMSKA.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The blue-violet dress establishes a broad shape before the smaller details of the face become prominent. The slightly averted head prevents the seated pose from becoming entirely frontal. Seen beside *Aline*, the portrait offers a useful comparison: a change of colour and posture can alter the figure's presence without requiring a different kind of setting.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3534

Keep the comparisons open

The two Calvaries, the two portraits by Jan de Smedt and the two drawings by Henri De Braekeleer make useful pairs. Compare one concrete feature before deciding which you prefer. Check current museum arrangements separately: this selection describes collection works and is not a promise of their availability on a particular day.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed explains how edges, masses and lines organize a figure. His practical chapters are a useful companion to the two De Braekeleer drawings and the portraits here.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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